architectural marvels I had earlier seen in Thanjavur itself, and much less interesting than another temple just across the road, which had been built in the shape of a giant stone linga and yoni. But perhaps the true real significance of the Punainallur Mariamman temple lies in the fact that large numbers of childless couples come here to pray for fertility, and if successful return to hang small cradles from the branches of the temple's tree. Sufferers in search of cures also come here to leave small effigies in clay showing the part of the body they believe to be affected. Here, as in all Amman temples, most of the worshippers are women drawn from the lower castes. They make offerings to the goddess in the traditional form of *mavilakku* – a sweet dish made of unrefined molasses, rice flour and separated butter – or *pongal*, a mix of rice and lentil cooked in terracotta pots. Brahmin priests may be in attendance but the actual rites themselves are said to be performed by laymen from the lower castes. To me and to other sceptics here is evidence that the worship of the Mother Goddess pre-dated the arrival of Brahminical Hinduism in the South.

As for Devi Kanyakumari, her extreme antiquity is vouched for by the unknown Greek or Roman author of *Periplus Maris Erythraei*, or 'Voyage round the Erythraean [i.e. Arabian] Sea'. This guide to the coastal regions of the Red Sea, Yemen, the Persian Gulf and India's western and eastern seaboards was written in the first century CE at a time when trading links between the Graeco-Roman and Indian worlds were at their peak. Its author appears to have been a very experienced trader or seafarer who had been there and done it all. After describing the various features of the Deccan's eastern seaboard he goes on to describe the cape itself, his words proving that even two thousand years ago it was linked both to a goddess and to asceticism:

> Next to this is another place called Komar, where is the cape of the same name and a haven. Those who wish to